

Website Migration Checklist

62-Point Zero-Downtime Guide

Most migration disasters trace back to four things: missing redirects, lost metadata, broken tracking, and no rollback plan. Work this checklist in order and you will avoid all four.

What's inside

- Full URL inventory and redirect mapping
- Metadata and structured data parity checks
- DNS, SSL, and TTL sequencing
- Analytics continuity and event parity
- Post-launch monitoring windows

Before You Touch Anything

- 01 Crawl and export every existing URL with status codes
- 02 Benchmark current rankings, traffic, and conversion rates
- 03 Snapshot all metadata, canonicals, and structured data
- 04 Lower DNS TTL to 300 seconds 48 hours ahead

Redirect Mapping

- 01 Map every old URL to its closest new equivalent
- 02 Use 301s, never 302s, for permanent moves
- 03 Avoid redirect chains — point directly to the final URL
- 04 Redirect to relevant pages, never blanket to the homepage

Launch Window

- 01 Deploy to staging with noindex and verify end to end
- 02 Confirm SSL and www/non-www canonical behaviour
- 03 Remove noindex before going live — the classic fatal mistake
- 04 Submit the new sitemap in Search Console immediately

First 30 Days

- 01 Monitor crawl errors and 404s daily for two weeks
- 02 Compare rankings weekly against your benchmark
- 03 Verify conversion tracking fires on every key event
- 04 Keep the old environment available for rollback

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